NUNO FONTOURA · FREE RESOURCE

READINESS CHECK

Before You Hire

A 20-minute check on whether your agency is ready to grow, before you add headcount.

Fillable PDF · 8 pages · 20 minutes

THE PREMISE

Another pair of hands, or a better structure?

Most agency founders hire when the pressure gets too high: another project manager, another pair of hands in delivery, another account lead. The relief lasts about a month. Then the same decisions queue up behind a bigger team, the same quotes and sign-offs wait on you, and the pressure comes back with a salary attached.

Sometimes the work really has outgrown the team. More often, the jobs, teams and suppliers still run through you, and a new person inherits that. This tells you which one you are looking at, before you post the job.

WHAT THIS IS BUILT ON

The Vessel Operating System

Every agency floats on three pillars. VOS looks at each one separately, because you can be strong in one and weak in another at the same time, and that gap is where the risk hides. It was built with founder-led production and brand activation agencies.

Strategy

The Bridge. Where the business is steered from: direction, ownership of decisions, and the plan people are actually rowing towards.

Systems

The Hull. What keeps you watertight: margin per job, numbers you trust, and production that holds without you on site.

Product

The Cargo Hold. What you carry to market: how jobs arrive, what you sell, and the clients who come back next season.

HOW TO USE IT

1. **Answer twelve statements**, four per pillar, from 1 to 5 (pages 2–4).
2. **Total your score** out of 60 and read the verdict (page 5).
3. **Price the hire** you are considering, then write the three things you will change first (pages 6–7).

Answer honestly, not aspirationally. Type into the grey fields and save the file, or print it and write by hand.

PILLAR 1 OF 3

The Bridge: strategy

Direction, ownership and the plan. A weak Bridge means delivery teams and account leads work hard in different directions, and a new hire inherits the confusion.

#	RATE EACH 1 (NOT TRUE AT ALL) TO 5 (COMPLETELY TRUE)	SCORE
1	My team knows which decisions they can make on a job without me, and which have to come to me.	
2	If I were away for two weeks, live jobs would keep moving to the same standard.	
3	We have a written plan for this quarter that we actually review.	
4	Anyone here could say in one sentence what we are best at building, and who we build it for.	

STRATEGY SUBTOTAL out of 20 · adds up on its own in Acrobat

THE STATEMENT YOU SCORED LOWEST

PILLAR 2 OF 3

The Hull: systems

Margin, numbers and delivery. A weak Hull means a new salary lands on a business that cannot yet see what it makes per job, or how much work the team can take.

#	RATE EACH 1 (NOT TRUE AT ALL) TO 5 (COMPLETELY TRUE)	SCORE
1	I know what we make on each job type, not just total revenue.	
2	The numbers I steer by come from one source everyone trusts.	
3	Quoting, delivery and handover run on a written process, not on me being in the room.	
4	I can see this week how much delivery capacity we actually have, across crew, studio and freelancers.	

SYSTEMS SUBTOTAL out of 20 · adds up on its own in Acrobat

THE STATEMENT YOU SCORED LOWEST

PILLAR 3 OF 3

The Cargo Hold: product

Demand, offer and retention. A weak Cargo Hold means you hire for jobs you hope will land, rather than work you can already see in the pipeline.

#	RATE EACH 1 (NOT TRUE AT ALL) TO 5 (COMPLETELY TRUE)	SCORE
1	New jobs come from more than one predictable source, not only repeat clients and referrals.	
2	I know roughly what it costs to win a client and what one is worth across a year.	
3	Our offer changes on purpose, not because a client asked.	
4	Something we do actively brings clients back for the next campaign. Retention is not luck.	

PRODUCT SUBTOTAL out of 20 · adds up on its own in Acrobat

THE STATEMENT YOU SCORED LOWEST

YOUR SCORE

What the number means

TOTAL SCORE out of 60 · the three subtotals added up

WEAKEST PILLAR strategy, systems or product

12–29 · Hiring now will multiply the problem

Whatever is unclear today gets copied onto the new person, and you end up managing the confusion as well as doing the work. Fix your two lowest-scoring statements first.

30–44 · Hire, but not yet

You have enough structure to absorb someone, but not enough for them to work without you. Put two things in place before the offer goes out.

45–60 · You are ready

The risk now is losing what works as you grow. Write down what currently holds it together, before a new person changes it.

Read the pillars, not just the total. A business strong in two pillars and weak in one usually fails at the weak one, whatever the total says. If your lowest subtotal is strategy, a hire will not fix it. If it is systems, a hire will expose it.

THE OTHER SIDE OF THE DECISION

What hiring anyway will cost you

Before you post the job, fill this in with your own numbers. Not the day rate or salary you have in your head: the whole cost of the first year, including the time it takes off you.

COST	YOUR FIGURE
Salary	
Employer National Insurance and pension	
Recruitment fee, or your time to hire	
Laptop, software, desk, tools or equipment	
Your hours onboarding them, at what your hour is worth	
Your hours managing them each week, for the first six months	
First-year total	

> Now put that number next to your score. Under 30, it is the price of hiring into a structure that is not ready for the person.

BEFORE YOU HIRE, OR BEFORE THEY START

Your three next steps

Take them straight from your answers: the two statements you scored lowest, and the pillar with the weakest subtotal. Those are the gaps a new person would inherit.

Three things, not ten. Each one needs a name and a date, or it will not happen. If a step is really a project, write the first week of it instead.

WEAKEST PILLAR (FROM PAGE 5)

YOUR TWO LOWEST-SCORING STATEMENTS

STEP 1

WHAT CHANGES

WHO OWNS IT

BY WHEN

STEP 2

WHAT CHANGES

WHO OWNS IT

BY WHEN

STEP 3

WHAT CHANGES

WHO OWNS IT

BY WHEN

WHERE THIS STOPS

What this check does not cover

This tells you whether you are ready to hire, and what it is likely to cost if you are not. It does not tell you where the agency is actually stuck, or in what order to fix things.

That is a different piece of work: finding the one constraint holding everything else back, and sequencing the fixes so they hold under pressure. Twelve statements cannot do that, and any tool that claims to is selling you something.

THE FULLER PICTURE

The free VOS assessment scores nine areas across the three pillars, from 0 to 100, and names the area to look at first.

A 30-minute discovery call reads your answers with you. I will tell you honestly whether hiring is the right next move, whether or not we work together.

Want to install this properly?

You have the symptoms. The free VOS assessment turns them into a Business Health score across all nine areas, so you know what to fix before you add anyone.

Take the free VOS assessment | **Book a discovery call**

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